

alone card, which plugs in to your motherboard and has its own memory, BIOS and Graphics Processing Unit or GPU. The old 3D cards used to connect to your motherboard via a PCI slot, but advances in technology meant that the data transfer rate that the slot allowed became too slow. This led to the creation of the



AGP or Advanced Graphics Port. Today even AGP stands on the threshold of extinction, with PCI-E or PCI Express quickly becoming the favoured standard. Further, the newest developments have allowed user to buy two, yes two 3D cards and harness the power of both at the same time to give greater performance. This feature, known popularly as SLi graphics, is being offered by both the major players in the 3D accelerator business—Nvidia and ATI.

Once again the equation is pretty simple— the better your graphics card, the better your visual performance. Your requirement is governed by the types of games you play. Thus, for e.g., someone who only plays the latest FPS games will require a cutting edge 3D card with the best features, but if Pac-Man is your thing then onboard graphics more than meet your requirements.

Sound

Until a few years ago, sound was probably the most ignored aspect of gaming. While everyone went gaga over the graphics of a game, sound would remain largely ignored. Things have changed though. With developers putting more and more thought and effort into the sound of the game, speakers and soundcards have become an integral part of a gamers hardware. The most